



Log in before you boot up with SafeBoot

drive has 10 per cent of its drive volume encrypted. You can use this to try out drive encryption, but ideally, choose to encrypt the whole drive. You can also create a custom warning message at boot time.

After this, the installer starts copying all the additional setup files. Keep a blank formatted floppy diskette handy, as you will be prompted to create a rescue diskette. Once done, you can extract it from the drive. If you chose to encrypt drives, then SafeBoot will conduct the drive encryption operation immediately. You can choose to either reboot, or continue working with SafeBoot in the background; you can also stop and restart it later. To view the status of encryption, just right-click on the SafeBoot icon and choose Show Status.

Booting up: The primary aim of any security tool is to prevent unauthorized users from logging on to the computer. With SafeBoot installed, you are presented with a login screen when the computer is turned on. On the SafeBoot login screen you will also find additional options to either boot from hard drive or floppy—these options are accessible from the Options button. Once you authenti-

cate, Windows boots up normally.

Usage: While you work with Windows, SafeBoot resides in the system tray. Double-clicking on the SafeBoot icon launches your screen-saver and locks your computer. You need to re-enter your Windows password to continue working.

Drive Encryption: While SafeBoot forces you to authenticate before Windows loads up, to safeguard your data, you should encrypt your hard drives. This will prevent someone from just removing your hard drive and reading

your data on another laptop. SafeBoot's encryption works on a real-time basis—files read from an encrypted drive are encrypted and decrypted on the fly. SafeBoot does not offer you a choice of

encryption algorithm. It uses the AES algorithm (the Advanced Encryption Standard) implemented with 256-bit security.

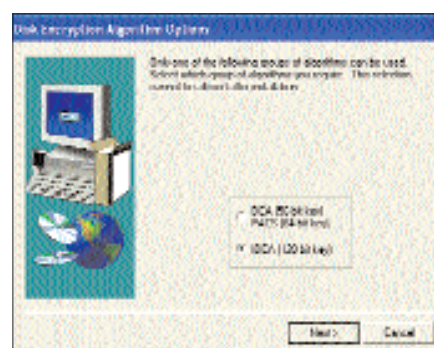
If you have not encrypted your drives during installation, you can do so by right-clicking on the SafeBoot icon in the system tray and choosing Configure. You need to enter your username and password. You will also be prompted to reuse the rescue disk you created earlier.

TIP The AES algorithm is the current data encryption standard approved for usage by the US government. It arose as a result of a world-wide competition for a next generation encryption algorithm for NIST (National Institute of Standards and Technology).

ProtectDrive

Eracom's ProtectDrive (<http://www.eracon-tech.com/products/pd/pdrive.htm>) is a highly configurable tool. This is purely commercial software—the demo version is insecure and displays the username and password of the ProtectDrive administrator.

Installation: Installing ProtectDrive is a two-step routine: launch the pre-installation program by double-clicking on the setup file. After you agree to the license

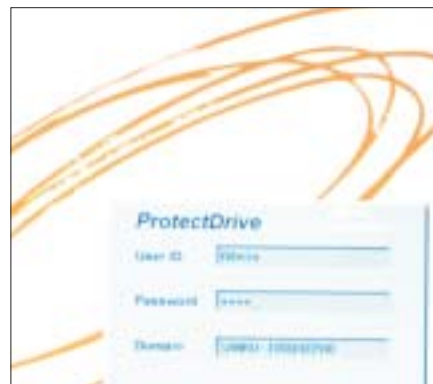


Choose your flavour of encryption security, between IDEA or DES and PACS

agreements, ProtectDrive copies the main setup files to the hard drive and prompts you to reboot. Following a reboot, the main installation program starts. Keep a formatted floppy handy, as you will have to create a rescue disk. You need this disk to recover from crashes, failures and also to uninstall ProtectDrive. After creating the rescue disk, you head off to the Configuration Options screen, where you can set options for both the ProtectDrive Administrator, as well as other users, such as allowing them the password recovery option and synchronizing to local Windows accounts, as well as setting the minimum length of the password.

The default values work fine, but if you're paranoid, avoid the synchronization and increase the minimum password length. Now you can choose the encryption algorithms that you want—DES (Data Encryption Standard) offers 56-bit security, the proprietary PACS algorithm that uses a 64-bit key, or the IDEA (International Data Encryption Algorithm) that uses a 128-bit key.

The higher the encryption key size, the more time you'll spend encrypting and decrypting data—keep this in mind while choosing your algorithm. Finally, the program files are copied on to the hard drive.



Booting up with ProtectDrive

Tracking it Down

Welcome to the world of laptop squealers; like the 'LoJack' tracking device mounted on vehicles to identify and track stolen vehicles, there exist tracking software utilities that beep their location as soon as the laptop gets online. Checkout services such as AbsoluteSoftware's CompuTrace service (www.computrace.com), zTrace (www.ztrace.com), or Stealth Signal

(www.stealthsignal.com). You have to install the software and pay a rental for the service, generally yearly. Once you report your laptop stolen or lost, it is tracked and the information is shared with local law enforcement agencies. Unfortunately the services are not cheap—in excess of \$40 per year of usage. Moreover, the services appear to be partial towards the US.